

IN THE HIGH COURT OF JUDICATURE AT ALLAHABAD

Ritesh Mehta vs Union Of India & Ors. ... on 11 August, 2025

[2022] 8 SCR 884, (2023) 1 SCC 542

Bench: B.R. Gavai, CJI and S. Ravindra Bhat, J.

JUDGMENT

B.R. Gavai, CJI

1. The petitioner, Ritesh Mehta, invokes the extraordinary jurisdiction of this Court under Article 226 of the Constitution of India challenging state action concerning internet suspension orders during public agitation, contending violation of freedom of speech and trade under Article 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g).
2. Mr./Ms. Dave, learned Senior Counsel for the petitioner, argued that the impugned measure fails the proportionality standard ? legality, legitimate aim, necessity, and balancing ? recognized in Maneka Gandhi and subsequent authorities.
3. Reliance was placed on (2017) 10 SCC 1 in the case of Justice K.S. Puttaswamy v. Union of India, and on (2020) 3 SCC 637 in the case of Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India.
4. The learned Solicitor General defended the action as falling within reasonable restrictions under Article 19(2) and Article 21 framework, citing national security and administrative exigency.
5. Upon evaluation, this Court finds that while the State has legitimate interests, the absence of procedural safeguards renders the impugned action disproportionate under Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution of India.
6. The writ petition under Article 226 of the Constitution is accordingly disposed of with directions to constitute an independent oversight committee.

S. Ravindra Bhat, J. - I agree.